

# Ally Quinn Story Backbone

## Round Two Consensus Response to Claude

Prepared for independent model-to-model adjudication

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### Contents

|                                                                                |          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>Round two verdict</b>                                                       | <b>1</b> |
| <b>Current consensus wording</b>                                               | <b>2</b> |
| <b>Settled points</b>                                                          | <b>2</b> |
| <b>Amendment one: what the test decides</b>                                    | <b>3</b> |
| Three separate decisions . . . . .                                             | 3        |
| <b>Amendment two: a third axis is necessary but not sufficient</b>             | <b>3</b> |
| Axis three: What does the player reconstruct? . . . . .                        | 3        |
| Required season-level variation field: How does the episode resolve? . . . . . | 4        |
| <b>Amendment three: separate resistance from clock</b>                         | <b>4</b> |
| Resistance field . . . . .                                                     | 4        |
| Clock field . . . . .                                                          | 4        |
| <b>The unresolved agency clause</b>                                            | <b>4</b> |
| Why the comparison point is wrong . . . . .                                    | 5        |
| Proposed replacement: consequence-and-agency gate . . . . .                    | 5        |
| Additional fairness test . . . . .                                             | 5        |
| <b>Correction: there is no one-fresh-case quota</b>                            | <b>5</b> |
| <b>Revised spoken-opening experiment</b>                                       | <b>5</b> |
| Six opening set . . . . .                                                      | 6        |
| Desk gate before testing . . . . .                                             | 6        |
| Table-read method . . . . .                                                    | 6        |
| Decision scope . . . . .                                                       | 6        |
| <b>Points requiring Claude's final ruling</b>                                  | <b>6</b> |
| <b>Round two status table</b>                                                  | <b>7</b> |
| <b>Revision history</b>                                                        | <b>7</b> |

### Round two verdict

#### PROVISIONAL CONSENSUS PENDING ONE RULE DECISION AND THE SPOKEN-OPENING TEST

Claude's second response resolves most of the substantive disagreement. Its withdrawals are accepted without qualification:

- Access to closed-case material improves, but does not become automatic.
- A passive beneficiary is not an antagonist.

- The clock problem does not end.
- A free killer is not permanent jeopardy.
- The original binary tester question was leading and should be discarded.

Claude also made three useful advances:

1. Add a player-activity axis to the case taxonomy.
2. Remove deadlines from the list of resistance forms.
3. Test performed cold opens rather than written premise cards.

The remaining material disagreement is the proposed requirement that at least one reachable ending leave a named person worse off than at the open, caused by the player. That clause correctly detects retrospective safety, but its chosen comparison point and incentive structure are unsafe.

## Current consensus wording

**Internal engine:** The record is wrong, and somebody is still living with the consequence.

**Player-facing promise:** Ally Quinn reopens the cases Havenbay has decided are over.

**Episode construction rule:** A contested record, a live human consequence, rational resistance, reconstructive play, consequential agency, and an accountable resolution.

The first two lines are settled. The third line is provisionally settled, pending the agency gate below.

## Settled points

| Issue                    | Round two ruling     | Consequence                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lawful access            | Settled              | Evidence custody remains Kill Gate Zero. Every decisive item needs an owner, lawful disclosure path, and limit.                |
| Antagonist               | Settled              | A passive beneficiary is not enough. Every episode needs rational active resistance, but not necessarily a pursuing killer.    |
| Clock                    | Settled              | The clock is a separate field. It is not opposition and is not mandatory when current harm is already accumulating.            |
| Jeopardy premise         | Settled              | Historical murder, impunity, or injustice is a foundation, not present jeopardy by itself.                                     |
| Original tester question | Settled              | Discard it. It names the categories and asks testers to predict their own behaviour.                                           |
| Test medium              | Settled              | Use performed cold opens, not written summaries. The shipped product lands through listening-speed events and player activity. |
| Player-activity taxonomy | Settled in principle | Track what the player reconstructs, not only what is wrong with the record.                                                    |

| Issue       | Round two ruling | Consequence                                                                                      |
|-------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Slack Water | Settled          | Exclude it until the full pitch is in the shared packet. No unauditable reasoning.               |
| Listener    | Settled          | It remains demoted and does not earn a season slot until it passes a new jeopardy and pull test. |

## Amendment one: what the test decides

Claude is right that the test should not decide whether the project may use closed-record cases, lawful archive access, pause-safe clocks, or reconstruction. Those improvements can be adopted as design tools now.

Claude goes too far in saying the test decides exclusivity only. A franchise backbone is not merely a production technique. It is a repeated audience promise and a season-level allocation decision. Tester behaviour is relevant to whether contested records should dominate the main episodes and whether such a case should launch the game.

## Three separate decisions

1. **Adopt now:** Contested records, lawful evidence mapping, pause-safe clocks, and reconstructive investigation become approved story tools.
2. **Pending the spoken-opening test:** Whether contested-record cases become the dominant main-episode backbone and player-facing promise.
3. **Pending the same test plus full pitches:** Whether the pilot should be a contested-record case or a fresh murder.

The test therefore does not gate every structural improvement. It gates dominance, marketing promise, and pilot family. Exclusivity is not recommended at all.

One further correction: “antagonist rationality” is not a structural fact supplied by an old case. An old case removes the need for a killer to stage elaborate new crimes, but a credible resistance system still has to be written. The change reduces one failure mode. It does not solve opposition automatically.

## Amendment two: a third axis is necessary but not sufficient

Claude’s third axis is accepted:

### Axis three: What does the player reconstruct?

Candidate forms include:

- a recording;
- a document set;
- an environmental model such as tide, weather, visibility, or travel time;
- a person’s identity;
- a timeline;
- a route or voyage;
- a place that no longer exists;
- the custody history of an object;
- a network of relationships or payments.

No reconstruction form should repeat in consecutive main episodes. The physical activity must be named at pitch stage, and the merge requirements must be the reconstruction rather than merely the price of reaching it.

However, the claim that this is the only axis the player experiences directly is too broad. The player also directly experiences decisions, social consequences, pacing, and endings. Two episodes can reconstruct different objects and still feel formulaic if both end with the same confession, arrest, or podcast publication.

### **Required season-level variation field: How does the episode resolve?**

This does not need to become another case taxonomy. It does need a visible season audit. Candidate resolution modes include:

- legal review or exoneration;
- protection of a keeper or future victim;
- public correction without prosecution;
- institutional exposure;
- confession or confrontation;
- recovery, identification, or return of remains or property;
- a deliberately limited publication to prevent further harm;
- a partial remedy with a named cost;
- a culprit exposed but not yet chargeable.

Neither reconstruction mode nor resolution mode should repeat in consecutive episodes. This is the pair that catches “sixteen leads of paper, then an arrest” even when the case cells differ.

## **Amendment three: separate resistance from clock**

Claude’s deletion is accepted.

### **Resistance field**

Resistance must come from a rational actor or system that benefits from, depends on, or is protected by the accepted record. Examples include:

- a person protecting liberty, access, money, status, family, or reputation;
- an institution protecting legitimacy, liability, or authority;
- a witness or keeper protecting another person or a dangerous secret;
- a community enforcing a shared account;
- an evidentiary constraint created by lawful custody, degradation, or prior error.

### **Clock field**

A clock is separate and optional. If used, it must be pause-safe and case-born: a scheduled hearing, transfer, lawful disposal, demolition, appointment, payment, or official decision. A deadline never counts as resistance.

## **The unresolved agency clause**

Claude’s diagnosis is strong:

A retrospective backbone can reproduce The Listener with better production values because the harm is already done and nothing the player does can make anything worse.

That is the most serious risk in the proposal.

The proposed cure is:

At least one reachable ending must leave a named person worse off than at the open, caused by the player.

This should not be adopted as written.

## Why the comparison point is wrong

- A case may open with a person imprisoned, endangered, publicly condemned, or denied a body to bury. Every credible ending may improve that person's position while still carrying major consequence.
- The rule can be satisfied by adding an obviously foolish option or a sacrificial branch. That proves content exists, not that the player faced a fair dilemma.
- It incentivises manufactured harm because harm becomes a compliance item.
- It can punish competent ethical play. Stakes exist when a bad outcome is credibly possible, not only when the shipped ending leaves somebody below their opening state.
- It makes "caused by the player" sound like culpability is the design goal. The goal is consequential responsibility under uncertainty.

## Proposed replacement: consequence-and-agency gate

**Consequence-and-agency gate:** Before resolution, at least one material decision must force the player to choose between competing, credible risks affecting named people or an irreversible evidentiary or publication outcome. No option may be consequence-free. At least two reachable end states must differ materially in who is protected, exposed, believed, harmed, or denied remedy. At least one fair branch must realise a material and irreversible cost that another fair branch avoids. Any harmful outcome must arise causally from a signalled investigative or publication choice, not luck, withheld information, or an obviously foolish option. If removing the player's decisions leaves every named person's outcome unchanged, the episode fails.

This preserves Claude's worse-world insight while comparing branches with each other rather than requiring a victim to finish below an already terrible opening state.

## Additional fairness test

For every consequential decision, the pitch must state:

1. what the player knows at the moment of choice;
2. which risk each option carries;
3. why a reasonable player might choose either option;
4. what later evidence changes the interpretation;
5. which consequence cannot be undone.

If one option is obviously correct before the choice, it is not agency. If the decisive information is withheld solely to manufacture regret, it is not fair play.

## Correction: there is no one-fresh-case quota

Claude states that if fresh cases are capped at one per season, The Listener has already spent the slot at Episode Three.

No such cap appears in the round-one brief. The provisional one-per-season limit applied to **wrongful conviction**, not fresh cases. Fresh murders were described as controlled exceptions, with no numeric quota.

More importantly, a failed story cannot reserve a scarce slot. The Listener remains unallocated until it passes a new version of the jeopardy, agency, and cold-open tests.

The season mix remains an outcome of the spoken-opening test and later full-pitch ranking.

## Revised spoken-opening experiment

Claude's proposed next action is accepted with one sequencing amendment: settle the consequence-and-agency wording first, then write the six openings to the same template.

## Six opening set

- Two fresh murders.
- Two never-solved or misclassified murders.
- Two officially solved but contested murders.
- Each opening approximately one hundred and twenty to one hundred and sixty spoken words.
- Each opening must dramatise an event rather than explain a premise.
- Each must name or make legible the live consequence, rational resistance, reconstructive activity, and first consequential decision.
- No titles or category labels in the test version.
- All six must comply with the VO-lock conventions and parse at listening speed.

## Desk gate before testing

Reject an opening before table read if it cannot answer all five questions:

1. What happens in the first thirty seconds?
2. Who can be materially affected now?
3. What rational force resists correction?
4. What will the player's hands reconstruct?
5. What first choice can change the case rather than a line of dialogue?

If either contested-record pair cannot be written to the same dramatic standard as the fresh pair, the dominance hypothesis fails at the desk.

## Table-read method

- Read all six aloud in randomised order with the same performer and restrained delivery.
- Do not explain the case family or the hypothesis.
- After all six, force each tester to choose the one they would play first, the one they would try second, and the one they would stop on.
- Ask: "What happened that made you choose that one?"
- Ask: "At what line did you decide?"
- Ask: "Who or what did you think was at risk?"
- Do not ask whether they prefer cold cases or fresh murders.

## Decision scope

- The result decides which family has the strongest pilot pull.
- It informs whether contested records should dominate the main-episode slate.
- It does not revoke the approved use of contested records, reconstruction, lawful access maps, or pause-safe clocks.
- It does not impose exclusivity.

## Points requiring Claude's final ruling

Claude should now answer only the remaining points:

1. Does the three-decision scope correctly separate approved tools, dominant backbone, and pilot family?
2. Does the consequence-and-agency gate retain the intended worse-world test without incentivising gratuitous harm?
3. If not, what exact wording is superior, and how does it avoid both retrospective safety and sacrificial branches?
4. Is resolution mode required alongside reconstruction mode in the season anti-formula audit?
5. Does Claude accept that no one-fresh-case quota was proposed and that The Listener occupies no slot while failed?
6. Is the revised six-opening experiment ready to execute after the agency wording is settled?

Round two status table

| Status     | Items                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Settled    | Access, evidence custody, active resistance, clocks separated from opposition, no automatic jeopardy, player-activity axis, spoken openings, Slack Water excluded, Listener still demoted. |
| Amended    | Test scope, anti-formula audit, performed-opening design.                                                                                                                                  |
| Unresolved | Exact consequence-and-agency gate; whether resolution mode is a required season variation field.                                                                                           |

The present verdict remains **PROVISIONAL CONSENSUS PENDING ONE RULE DECISION AND THE SPOKEN-OPENING TEST.**

Revision history

| Version | Date           | Change                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|---------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1.0     | 24 August 2026 | Initial consensus brief.                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 1.1     | 24 August 2026 | Incorporates Claude’s withdrawals and amendments, adds player reconstruction and resolution variation, separates resistance from clocks, corrects the fresh-case quota misread, and proposes a fairer agency gate. |